

How much of UAE seaborne trade still depends on the Strait of Hormuz?

UAE port activity during the 2026 closure of the strait (1 March – 25 September), from IMF PortWatch vessel-tracking (AIS) estimates validated against official port figures. Cargo-vessel transits registered by AIS fell from 70–100 a day in 2025 to 3–13 a day.

BOTTOM LINE

- FINDING** Seven months into the closure, UAE ports moved just over a quarter of their expected cargo: **27.7%** of the reference tonnage across all segments, and only **16.1%** for containers.
- FINDING** Fujairah and Khor Fakkan, the two ports outside the strait, took diverted containers but offset only **4.2%** of the Gulf-coast container loss. Across all cargo they lost volume themselves (**–23.7 Mt**), because Fujairah's tanker traffic fell.
- FINDING** At current scale they cannot replace Jebel Ali: their container capacity is about **30%** of Jebel Ali's, Khor Fakkan stopped growing after July, and the Abu Dhabi–Fujairah rail freight service only started on 27 September.
- The "Zero Hormuz" goal has no public indicator. This monitor offers one, by cargo segment, refreshed weekly from open data.

27.7%

UAE port activity preserved, all cargo

Range 26.2–28.2% (5 baselines)

16.1%

Container activity preserved

Range 14.5–16.2%

4.2%

Share of the Gulf-coast container loss offset by the east coast

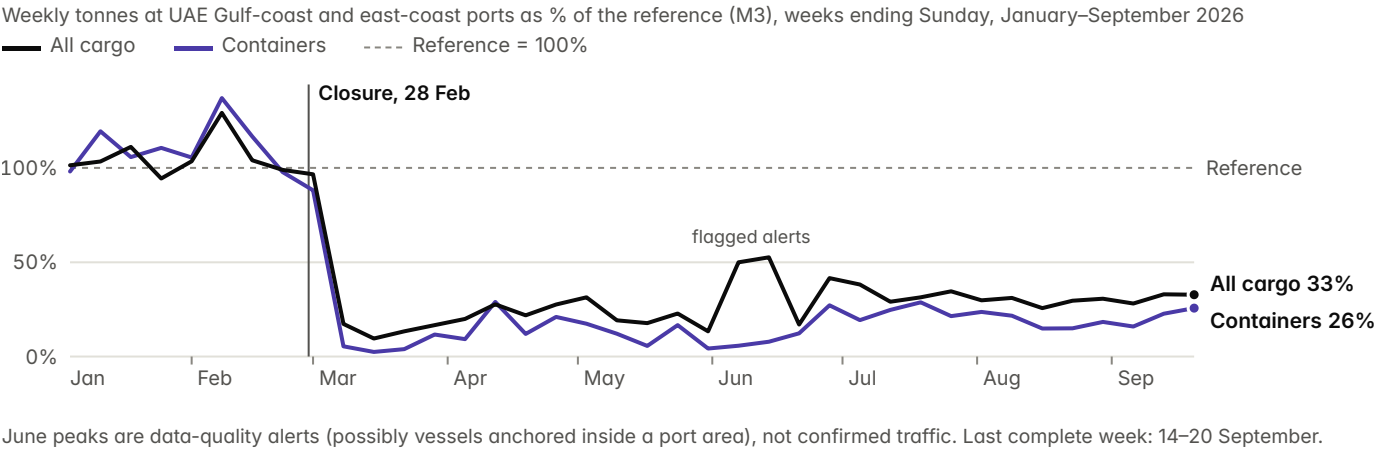
Range 4.2–4.7%

211 Mt

Gap vs the historical reference, all cargo

Range 206–227 Mt

Activity collapsed in the first week of March and has not recovered



Where the volume went, by cargo segment

Million tonnes (Mt), 1 March – 25 September 2026, reference M3. Changes are actual minus reference.

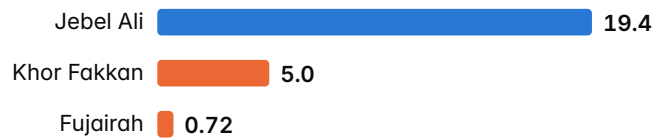
Cargo segment	Reference	Observed	Gulf coast change	East coast change	Gap vs reference	Activity preserved (M3) · range M1–M5
Containers	118.7	19.2	–104.0	+4.4	99.6	16.1% 14.5–16.2
General cargo + RoRo	5.3	3.2	–2.5	+0.3	2.2	59.3% 39.4–59.3
Dry bulk	58.5	26.8	–33.6	+1.9	31.7	45.8% 41.3–45.8
Tankers	109.5	31.7	–47.5	–30.3	77.8	29.0% 29.0–34.0
All cargo	292.0	80.8	–187.5	–23.7	211.3	27.7% 26.2–28.2

Gap = difference in activity relative to the historical reference; its recovery and possible redistribution are assessed through separate scenarios. It does not measure unmet demand or required capacity. Ranges = minimum and maximum across baselines M1–M5, not confidence intervals. Oman (comparison only): attributable volume not identified, no compensation credited.

Why the east coast cannot replace Jebel Ali

1 · SIZE

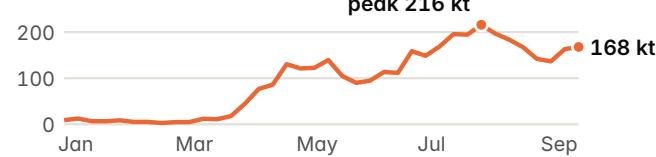
About 30% of Jebel Ali's container capacity



FINDING Official container capacity, million TEU a year: the two east-coast ports add up to 5.7, against 19.4 at Jebel Ali.

3 · SATURATION

Khor Fakkan stopped growing after July



FINDING Container tonnes (kt), 4-week average. In July the operator reported ~65,000 TEU a week, about 97% of its 3.5 M TEU yearly capacity. The average peaked at 216 kt (2 Aug) and fell 22% by 20 Sep, despite expansion to 5 M TEU.

FINDING At its best four-week run, the whole east coast moved about 7% of the container tonnes Jebel Ali handled in a normal week. Drewry reached a similar view in March: no mix of alternative ports and land logistics fully replaces Hormuz in the short term.

What this means for the "Zero Hormuz" strategy

FINDING Containers carry the deepest dependence. Container activity stayed 84% below reference; Jebel Ali ran near 13% of reference in Aug–Sep. **HYPOTHESIS** It follows the strait, not its own capacity (preliminarily supported).

FINDING Oman is not yet a measurable outlet. No diversion to Sohar, Salalah or Duqm stands out from normal noise; crediting it needs customs or corridor evidence.

FINDING Value is not volume. UAE non-oil foreign trade grew 13.1% in H1 2026 while container tonnage collapsed. **HYPOTHESIS** Gold and high-value air cargo explain most of it (untested).

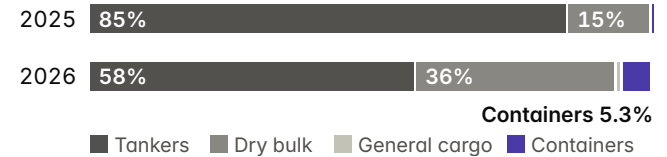
Where to investigate next: rail and truck volumes between the east coast and Gulf-side hubs, Khor Fakkan's throughput after expansion, and Fujairah's container berths. The monitor informs these decisions; it does not size investments.

Method

Daily import + export tonnes (AIS-based estimates) for the 15 UAE port areas in PortWatch and three Omani ports, 2019–2026. **Activity preserved** = (Gulf + east-coast actual) ÷ (Gulf + east-coast reference). **Reference M3** = average of the same weekday 52 and 104 weeks earlier; four other baselines give the range. Backtest on three pre-closure windows, median weekly WAPE: M4 15.0%, M3 16.2%, M1 20.3%. **Limits:** estimates, not customs records; Hormuz transits used for trend only (PortWatch 31 vs Lloyd's List 73, 10–16 Aug); air, land and pipeline trade not covered.

2 · SPECIALIZATION

Fujairah is an oil and bulk port



FINDING Share of Fujairah's tonnes, 1 Mar – 25 Sep: containers rose only from 0.1% in 2025 to 5.3% in 2026.

4 · LAND CONNECTION

The inland links are only starting

FINDING **Rail:** Etihad Rail's Abu Dhabi–Fujairah freight service started on 27 Sep 2026, three times a week; Khor Fakkan is not on it. **Trucks:** too few, and multimodal routes costly and slow (AGBI, March). **Waits:** median anchorage 9.3 days at Fujairah, 4.8 at Khor Fakkan, 2–8 Aug (Portcast via Nautica; low confidence).

HYPOTHESIS Inland links, not quay capacity alone, limit what the east coast can serve.

Validation against official figures

Check (containers)	PortWatch	Official
Jebel Ali, Q2 2026 (DP World)	–90.9%	–90.1%
Jebel Ali, H1 2026 (DP World)	–58.9%	–59.5%
Khor Fakkan, Jun–Jul vs 2025 (Gulftainer)	×11.3	×8.1
AD Ports, Q2 2026 (different port sets)	–77.4%	–65.0%

Tonnes are compared with TEU only as percentage changes, never as levels.

Figure notes. Period 1 Mar – 25 Sep 2026 unless stated; estimated import + export tonnes (IMF PortWatch, retrieved 3 Oct 2026) or official TEU where marked. Gulf coast = Jebel Ali, Khalifa, Abu Dhabi, Dubai, Sharjah, Ajman, Umm al Qaiwain, Mina Saqr, Al Hamriyah, Jabal Az Zannah–Ruways, Jebel Dhanna, Das Island, Zirku Island; east coast = Fujairah, Khor Fakkan. Capacities, rail, trucking and waits come from operators and press. Finding = measured, with source; Hypothesis = explanation pending test. Code and data: Zero Hormuz Monitor v0.3. Independent analysis, not affiliated with the IMF or any port operator.